

a respectable period of time when you consider a large chunk of that was consumed by actually downloading the software. If you use a full install disc, it would probably be a lot quicker.

It was a pretty quick and simple install, so I think most users could handle it without breaking into a sweat.

Configuring the system

Now, this being Debian, it's a little different from the likes of an Ubuntu or openSUSE, which try to configure every little thing for you automatically. Yet I still had a lot of configuration to do. The first order of business was to get my wireless card working, which actually turned out to be a lot easier than I'd feared. I opened up Synaptic (the graphical package management tool) and then looked at the preferences to see what software sources were enabled.

I could see a couple of groups weren't ticked, such as software that doesn't comply with the Debian Free Software Guidelines—it seems the drivers for my wireless card fall into this group. I enabled non-DFSG software, refreshed the package list and searched for 'Intel', which yielded a few packages, but scrolling through the list I quickly found one relating to my Pro Wireless 3945 card. After a minute, the wireless light started flashing and I was able to log into my home network easily. Not too difficult, but most distributions have this driver working out of the box. It's only omitted here because it doesn't satisfy the DFSG that I understand.

I have to say at this point I was really impressed by the speed and responsiveness of the system—it seemed very snappy and a quick look at the resources monitor showed I was only using 145 MB of RAM, even with quite a few large programs open on my GNOME desktop.

Most of the basic software you would need is included by default—like OpenOffice.org, The GIMP, Rhythmbox, Pidgin and Icceweasel, which is great. Icceweasel is essentially a clone of Mozilla's Firefox, created in protest against the actions of Mozilla Corporation and its licensing process. It's actually repackaged from Firefox source code with minimal modifications, so all your extensions will work just fine. I've never had any problems with Icceweasel or noticed any real difference from Firefox to speak of.

I installed most of the additional software I needed via Synaptic and could get packages for other things like Gpodder [gpodder.org] from the developer's own website. Installing the .deb files wasn't quite as simple as double-clicking them, though. I had to open a terminal and use the 'dpkg -i' command, but I got there. I also noticed that the *Add/Remove Software* tool from Ubuntu is now included.

There were a couple of programs I couldn't find in any of the repositories, even the experimental ones, Gwibber [launchpad.net/gwibber] being a prime example. I had to download all the dependencies for it manually and then install from the source code I'd checked out with Bazaar [bazaar-vcs.org]. It was a bit awkward and at times I felt I wasn't doing things 'the Debian way' by trying to install cutting-edge software. The distribution is renowned for its stability and some critics would say, its slow adoption of



Figure 1: Initial desktop



Figure 2: Icceweasel with Swfdec

new software. That's a trade-off for the stability, I suppose.

The freedom-hating drivers for my nVidia graphics card were installed easily with Synaptic. I then had to run the *nvidia-xconfig* command manually in a terminal to update the X server settings. I installed the *nvidia-settings* package because I use it for switching between internal and external displays.

I also like to use the Compiz Fusion 3D desktop. Some people dismiss it as eye candy or frivolous decoration, but it's far more than that. The easiest way to install Compiz on Debian is through the fantastically named Repository Of Shame [shame.tuxfamily.org/repo/]. It contains everything you could need and provides handy meta packages for easy installation.

I should take a moment to point out the utterly tragic news that Shane Lee (a.k.a Shame), maintainer of this repository and well-respected Debian developer, sadly died last November. It's hard to know what to say. Words fail me but he was only 35 years old and he will be sorely missed. My deepest condolences to his family. The repo still seems to be working and I was able to install everything by following the simple instructions on the site.

It's hot, damn hot!

This being the stable branch of Debian, a lot of the software is quite old. Some prefer the term mature, but I missed things like GNOME 2.24 with its tabbed Nautilus file browser and other improvements. I looked at adding the latest GNOME, but it